

Session Two • Abu Bakr al-Siddiqؓ

Two Years, Three Months

11–13 AH • 632–634 CE

Bookend in

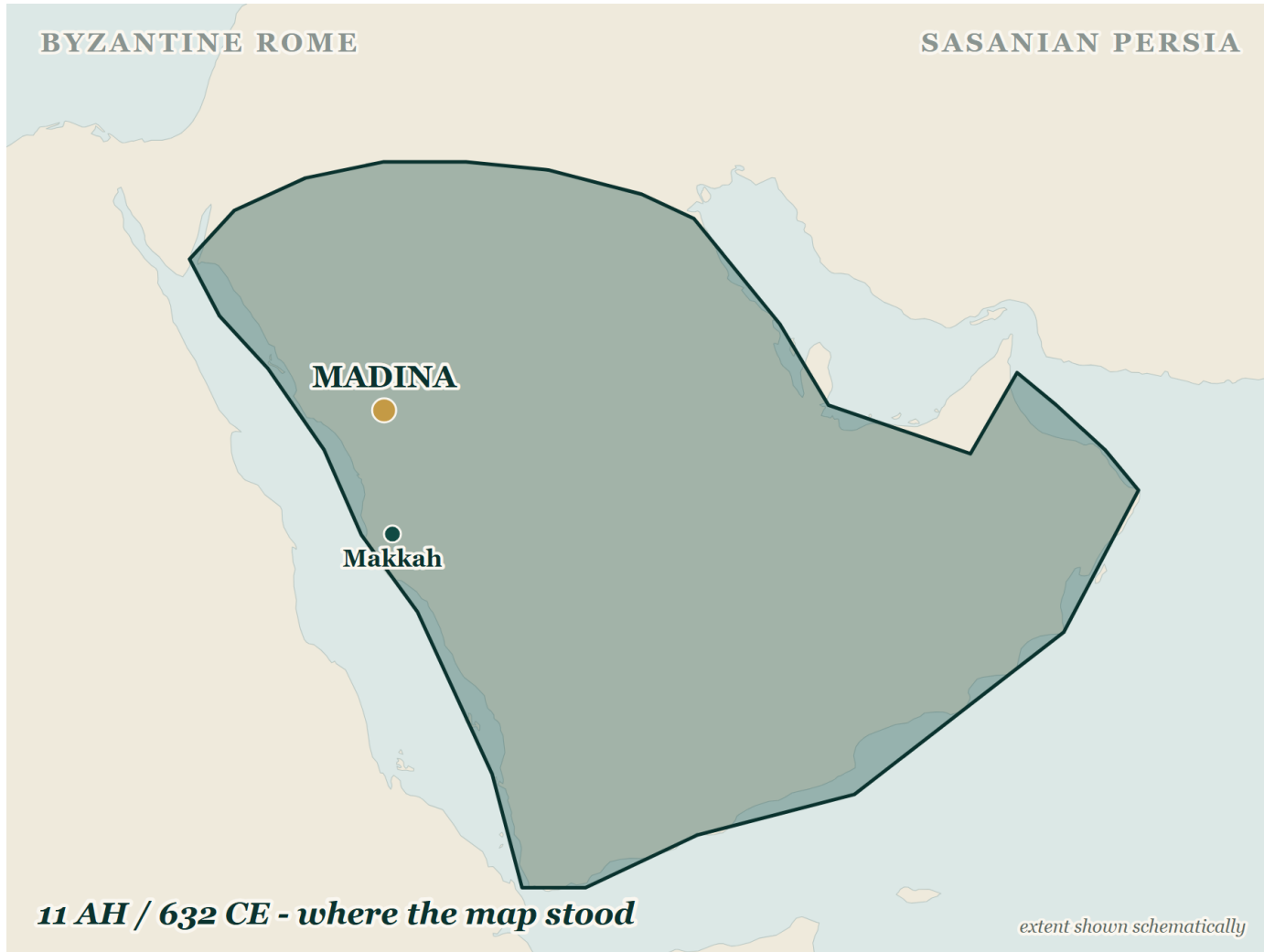
Where we stopped last week



The whole line. Tonight is the first two years of it.

11 AH

Arabia, the morning after



Medina

the capital, and one field army

The tribes around it

some broken away, some refusing the zakat

The army

raised for the Syrian frontier, not yet gone

Byzantine ground

north-west, well past Tabuk

The army he would not call back

Act One · 11 AH · the first ten days

How long was he caliph?

Two years and three months.

Shawwal 3 AH

The order of battle at Uhud

The right wing

Khalid b. al-Walid,
over the cavalry

The left wing

Ikrima, the son of Abu
Jahl

The army

Abu Sufyan b. Harb,
over all of it

All three of them command for Islam before the year 23.

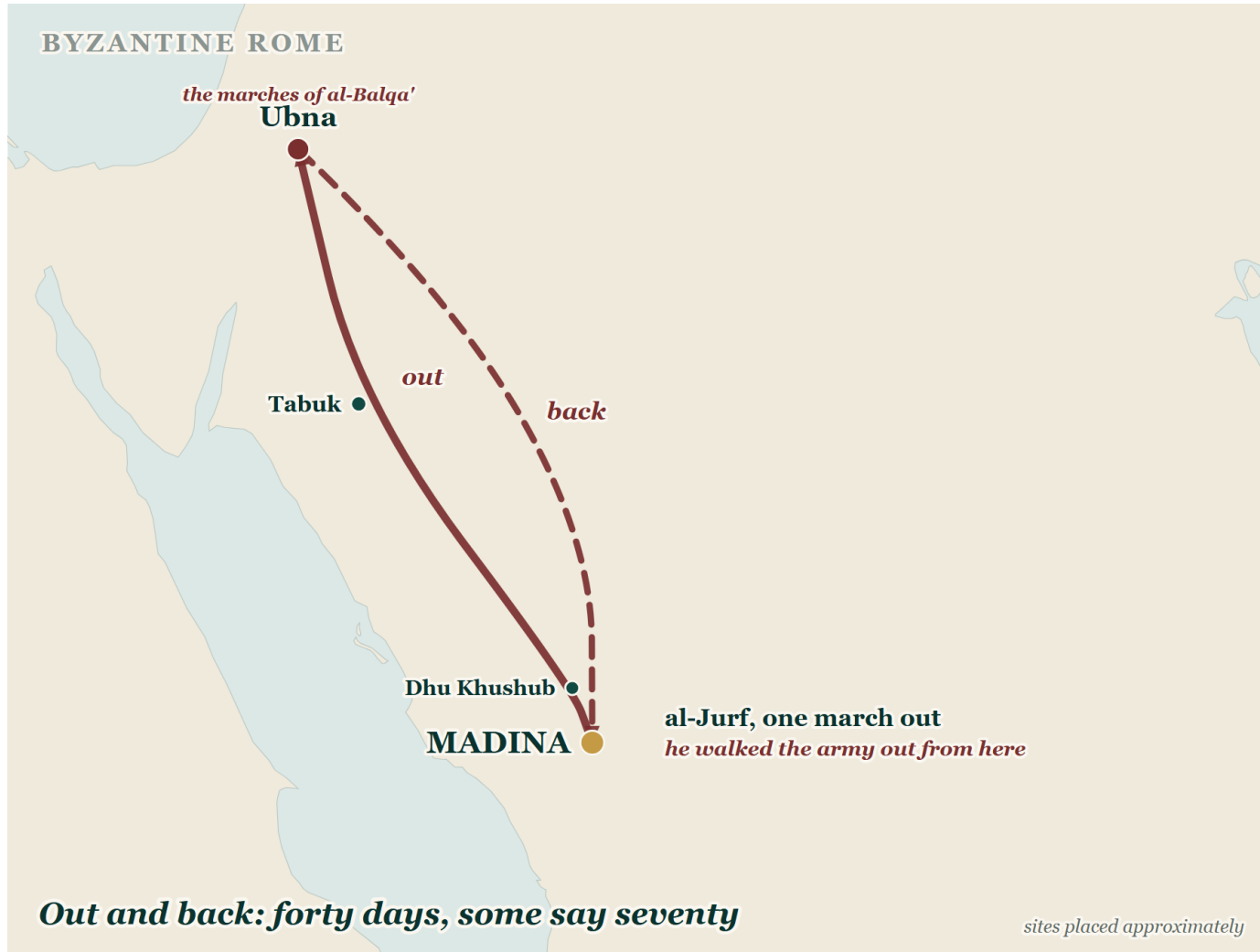
The two wings at Uhud

وَتَعَبَّأَتْ قُرَيْشٌ، وَهُمْ ثَلَاثَةُ آلَافٍ، وَمَعَهُمْ مِئَتَا فَرَسٍ قَدْ جَنَّبُوهَا، فَجَعَلُوا عَلَى
مَيْمَنَةِ الْخَيْلِ خَالِدَ بْنَ الْوَلِيدِ، وَعَلَى مِيسَرَّتِهَا عِكْرِمَةُ بْنُ أَبِي جَهْلٍ بْنُ هِشَامٍ

*They put Khalid b. al-Walid over the right wing of the cavalry,
and Ikrima b. Abi Jahl b. Hisham over its left.*

11 AH

An army pointed north



Medina

the army is raised here

Usama b. Zaydؓ

eighteen, and in command

al-Jurf

the camp one march out

Dhu Khushub

on the road north

Ubna, in the Balqa'

Byzantine ground

The Prophet ﷺ answered them himself

إِنْ تَطْعُنُوا فِي إِمَارَتِهِ فَقَدْ كُنْتُمْ تَطْعُنُونَ فِي إِمَارَةِ أَبِيهِ مِنْ قَبْلُ، وَائِمُّ اللَّهِ إِنْ كَانَ
لَخَلِيقًا لِلْإِمَارَةِ، وَإِنْ كَانَ لِمَنْ أَحَبَّ النَّاسَ إِلَيَّ، وَإِنَّ هَذَا لِمِنْ أَحَبِّ النَّاسِ إِلَيَّ

بَعْدَهُ

If you find fault with his command, you found fault with his father's command before him — and this one is among the dearest of people to me after him.

al-Bidaya wa-l-Nihaya, vol. 5, p. 311

Do you call the army back?

والذي نفس أبي بكر بيده لو ظننت أن السباع تخطفني لأنفذتُ بعثَ أسامة
كما أمرَ به رسولُ الله ﷺ؛ ولو لم يبقَ في القرى غيري لأنفذته

*By Him in whose hand is Abu Bakr's soul — if I thought the wild
beasts would snatch me away, I would still send out Usama's
expedition.*

And you order me to depose him?

تَكَلَّمْتُكَ أُمُّكَ يَا ابْنَ الْخَطَّابِ! اسْتَغْمَلَهُ رَسُولُ اللَّهِ - صَلَّى اللَّهُ عَلَيْهِ وَسَلَّمَ -
وَتَأْمُرُنِي أَنْ أَعْزِلَهُ؟!

May your mother lose you, son of al-Khattab! The Messenger of Allah ﷺ appointed him — and you order me to depose him?

late Rabi' al-Awwal 11 AH

The caliph on foot

IMAGE GOES HERE

Restrained editorial illustration in muted ochre, bone and deep teal. A wide dusty caravan track leaving a walled palm oasis at first light, seen from ground level. Deep camel prints and bare human footprints pressed side

expected: series/visuals/l02_walk_out.png

He walked. The commander rode. His own beast was led behind, empty.

late Rabi' al-Awwal 11 AH

Either you ride or I dismount

فقال أسامةُ: يا خليفةَ رسولِ الله: إما أن تركبَ وإما أن أنزلَ، فقال: والله

لستَ بنازلٍ ولستُ براكبٍ

Usama said: O successor of the Messenger of Allah, either you ride or I dismount. He said: By Allah, you shall not dismount, and I shall not ride.

Forty days, and what the tribes concluded

فجعل لا يمرُّ بقبيل يريدون الارتداد إلا قالوا: لولا أن لهؤلاء قوةً ما خرجَ مثلُ

هؤلاء من عندهم

He passed no tribe intending to break away but they said: were it not that these people have strength, men like these would not have gone out from among them.

Arabia comes apart

Act Two · 11 AH

The first engagement was a setback

فَخَرَجَ عَلَيْهِمُ الرِّدَاءُ بِأَنْحَاءٍ قَدْ نَفَخُوهَا ... فَانْفَرَّتْ إِبِلُ الْمُسْلِمِينَ وَهُمْ عَلَيْهَا،
وَرَجَعَتْ بِهِمْ إِلَى الْمَدِينَةِ، وَلَمْ يُصْرَعْ مُسْلِمٌ.

The reserve came out at them with skins they had inflated ... the Muslims' camels bolted with them on their backs and carried them back to Medina — and not one Muslim was thrown.

11 AH, the same night

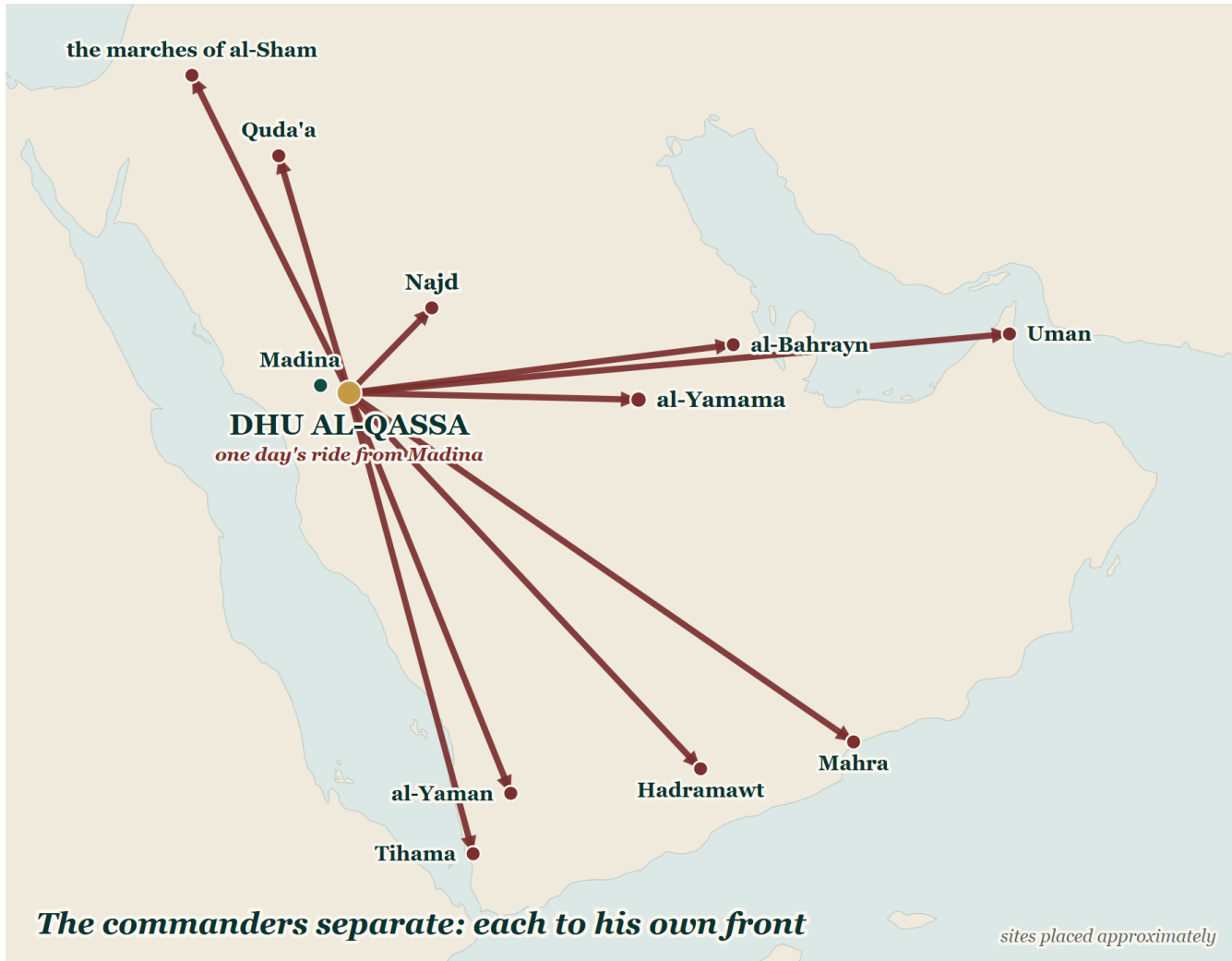
That was the first victory

فَمَا طَلَعَ الْفَجْرُ إِلَّا وَهُمْ وَالْعَدُوُّ عَلَى صَعِيدٍ وَاحِدٍ ... فَمَا ذَرَّ قَرْنُ الشَّمْسِ
حَتَّى وَلَّوْهُمْ الْأَذْبَارَ ... وَكَانَ أَوَّلَ الْفَتْحِ.

Dawn did not break until they and the enemy were on one ground ... and the sun's rim had not risen before they turned their backs ... and that was the first victory.

11 AH

Eleven banners at Dhu al-Qassa



Dhu al-Qassa

one day's ride out

Eleven commanders

each with written orders

North and east

Najd, Yamama, Sham

East and south-east

Bahrayn, Uman, Mahra

South

Yemen, Tihama, Hadramawt

Eleven directions from one camp

فَفَصَلَتْ الْأُمَرَاءُ مِنْ ذِي الْقَصَّةِ، وَلَحِقَ بِكُلِّ أَمِيرٍ جُنْدُهُ، وَعَهْدَ إِلَى كُلِّ أَمِيرٍ.

The commanders separated from Dhu al-Qassa, and each commander's troops joined him, and he gave each commander his commission.

11 AH

The letter went ahead of the armies

IMAGE GOES HERE

Restrained editorial still life in muted ochre, bone and deep teal. A single sheet of aged parchment lying open on a plain scrubbed wooden board, its writing suggested only as soft illegible strokes — never readable letters

expected: series/visuals/I02_letter.png

One wording, copied many times, carried ahead of the columns.

The letter set one test

وقد أمرتُ رسولي أن يقرأ كتابه في كلِّ مَجْمَعٍ لكم، والداعية الأذان، فإذا إِذَّنَ المسلمون فأذنوا فكُفُّوا عنهم، وإن لم يُؤدِّنوا فسلوهم ما عليهم.

I have ordered my messenger to read his letter in every assembly of yours. The summons is the adhan: when they call it, hold off from them; if they do not, ask them what they owe.

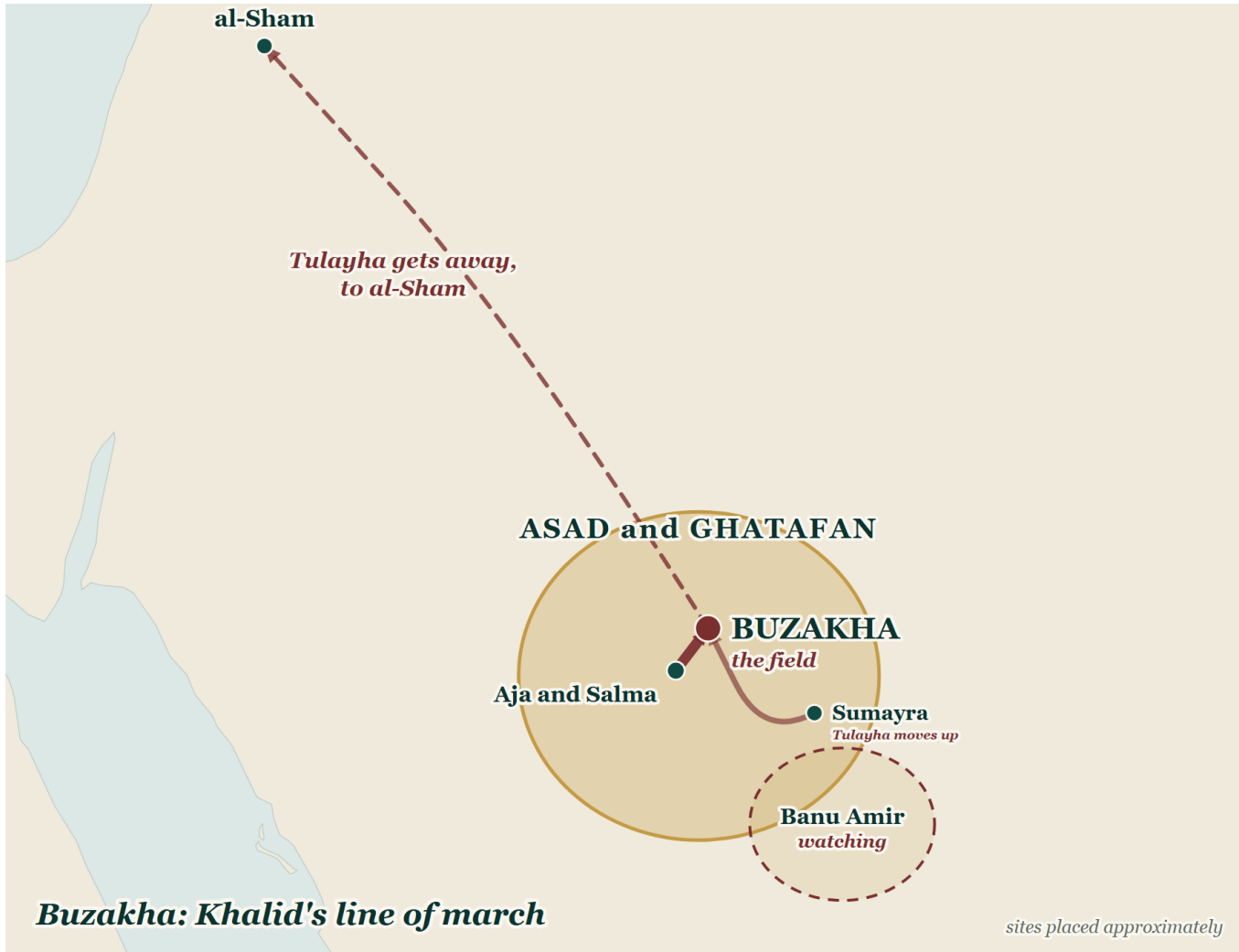
A sword among the swords of Allah

نِعْمَ عَبْدُ اللَّهِ وَأَخُو الْعَشِيرَةِ، خَالِدُ بْنُ الْوَلِيدِ، سَيْفٌ مِنْ سُيُوفِ اللَّهِ سَلَّهُ اللَّهُ
عَلَى الْكُفَّارِ وَالْمُنَافِقِينَ

*What an excellent servant of Allah and brother of the clan —
Khalid b. al-Walid; a sword among the swords of Allah, drawn
against the disbelievers and the hypocrites.*

11 AH

Buzakha



Aja' and Salma

Khalid ٱ starts here

Sumayra'

Tulayha moves up

Buzakha

Asad, Ghatafan, Fazara

Banu Amir

armed nearby, watching

Then to al-Sham

Tulayha's line of flight

The man who walked off the field

قَالَ لِي: إِنَّ لَكَ رَحًا كَرَحَاهُ، وَحَدِيثًا لَا تَنْسَاهُ. فَقَالَ عُيَيْنَةُ: قَدْ عَلِمَ اللَّهُ أَنَّهُ
سَيَكُونُ حَدِيثٌ لَا تَنْسَاهُ، انْصَرِفُوا يَا بَنِي فَزَارَةَ فَإِنَّهُ كَذَّابٌ.

He said to me: you have a mill like his mill, and a matter you will not forget. Uyayna said: Allah knows there will be a matter you will not forget. Withdraw, Banu Fazara — the man is a liar.
al-Kamil fi al-Tarikh, vol. 2, p. 205

What is defeating you?

مَا يَهْزِمُكُمْ؟ فَقَالَ رَجُلٌ: أَنَا أُحَدِّثُكَ، لَيْسَ مِنَّا رَجُلٌ إِلَّا وَهُوَ يُحِبُّ أَنْ يَمُوتَ
صَاحِبُهُ قَبْلَهُ، وَإِنَّا نَلْقَى قَوْمًا كُلُّهُمْ يُحِبُّ أَنْ يَمُوتَ قَبْلَ صَاحِبِهِ

Not one of us but would rather his companion died first — and we meet a people who would each rather die before his companion.

Siyar A'lam al-Nubala' (al-Khulafa' al-Rashidun), p. 41

11 AH, after Buzakha

One clause struck out in public

فَقَالَ عمر: أما قولك: تدون قتلانا، فإنّ قتلانا قتلوا على أمر الله لا ديات لهم
...وقال عمر في الثاني: نعم ما رأيت.

*Umar   said: as for your saying, and you pay blood-money for
our dead — our dead were killed upon the command of Allah;
there is no blood-money for them.*

al-Bidaya wa-l-Nihaya, vol. 7, p. 27 · Sahih al-Bukhari 7221

al-Yamama

Act Three · 11–12 AH · the hardest day of the war

Two brothers by appointment

وقد آخى رسول الله ﷺ وبين معن بن عديّ الأنصاري وقد قُتلا جميعًا
باليمامة.

The Messenger of Allah ﷺ made him and Ma'n b. Adi al-Ansari brothers, and the two of them were killed together at al-Yamama.

before Dar al-Arqam

The son of the elder of the Jahiliyya

السَّيِّدُ الْكَبِيرُ، الشَّهِيدُ، أَبُو حُذَيْفَةَ ابْنُ شَيْخِ الْجَاهِلِيَّةِ :عُتْبَةَ بْنِ رَبِيعَةَ ...

الْقُرَشِيُّ، الْعَبْشَمِيُّ، الْبَدْرِيُّ

The great chief, the martyr, Abu Hudhayfa — son of the elder of the Jahiliyya, Utba b. Rabi'a — al-Qurashi, al-Abshami, the man of Badr.

2 AH, after Badr

Something about your father

لا والله ما شككت في أبي ولا في مصرعه، ولكني كنت أعرف منه رأيا وحلما،
فكنت أرجو أن يسلم

*No, by Allah, I have not doubted my father nor where he fell.
But I knew in him a judgement and a forbearance, and I used to
hope he would accept Islam.*

Siyar A'lam al-Nubala' (al-Sira al-Nabawiyya), p. 312

before the hijra

Four titles, and one origin

مِنَ السَّابِقِينَ الْأَوَّلِينَ، الْبَدْرِيِّينَ، الْمُقَرَّبِينَ، الْعَالَمِينَ ... أَصْلُهُ مِنْ إِصْطَخْرَ

Of the first forerunners, of the men of Badr, of those brought near, of the learned ... his origin is from Istakhr.

before the Prophet ﷺ reached Medina

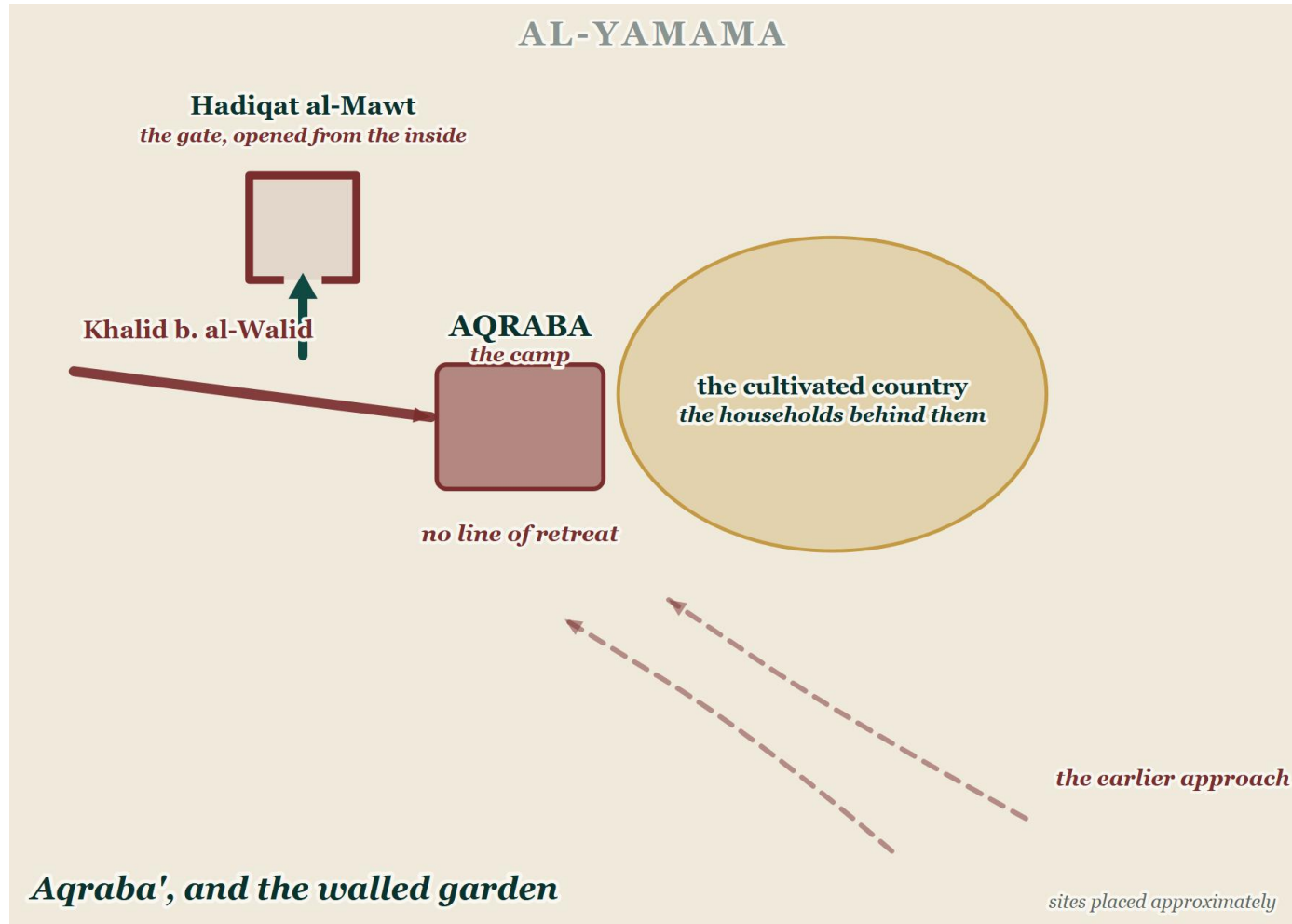
The imam at Quba'

أَنَّ الْمُهَاجِرِينَ نَزَلُوا بِالْعُصْبَةِ إِلَى جَنْبِ قُبَاءَ، فَأَمَّهُمْ سَالِمٌ مَوْلَى أَبِي حُذَيْفَةَ

The Muhajirun camped at al-Usba beside Quba', and Salim, the freedman of Abu Hudhayfa, led them in prayer.

11-12 AH

Aqraba'



al-Yamama

Khalid ٱ comes east

Aqraba'

on the cultivated edge

Behind the line

farmland and households

No line of retreat

back is through his home

Forty thousand

the men Musaylima had

Keep this one man alive

أيها الرجل إن كنت تريد بأهل اليمامة غداً خيراً أو شراً فاستبق هذا الرجل

... فاستبقاه خالد مقيداً، وجعله في الخيمة مع امرأته، وقال: استوصي به

خيراً.

Man — if you intend anything tomorrow for the people of Yamama, good or ill, keep this man alive ... so Khalid kept him, in irons, and said: treat him well.

al-Bidaya wa-l-Nihaya, vol. 7, p. 33

The line breaks

فكانت جولة وانهمزت الأعرابُ حتى دخلت بنو حنيفة خيمةَ خالد بن الوليد
وهمّوا بقتل أم تميم، حتى أجارها مجاعة وقال: نعمتِ الحرّةُ هذه.

Banu Hanifa entered Khalid b. al-Walid's own tent, minded to kill Umm Tamim — until Mujja'a gave her his protection.

The banner, and the vow of silence

وقال زيد بن الخطاب: أيها الناس عَضُّوا على أضراسكم، واضربوا في عدوكم

وامضوا قدمًا، وقال: والله لا أتكلّم حتى يهزمهم الله أو ألقى الله فأكلّمه

بحجّتي، فقتل شهيدًا

Bite down on your back teeth, strike into your enemy and go forward. By Allah, I will not speak until Allah routs them.

Are you not content to live praised?

فَقَالَ) : يَا ثَابِتُ ! أَمَا تَرْضَى أَنْ تَعِيشَ حَمِيداً، وَتُقْتَلَ شَهِيداً، وَتَدْخُلَ الْجَنَّةَ)

He said: Thabit — are you not content to live praised, to be killed a martyr, and to enter the Garden?

at Aqraba'

He put on his burial garments

IMAGE GOES HERE

Restrained editorial still life in muted bone, ochre and deep teal. Two plain undyed white cotton garments, freshly folded, resting on a low rough wooden bench; beside them a small unglazed clay vessel of perfume with it

expected: series/visuals/l02_shroud_garments.png

Thabit b. Qays ٧ — burial perfume, while the line went backwards.

at Aqraba'

This is not how we used to fight

هَكَذَا عَنْ وُجُوهِِنَا نُقَارِعُ الْقَوْمَ، بِئْسَ مَا عَوَّدْتُمْ أَقْرَانَكُمْ، مَا هَكَذَا كُنَّا نُقَاتِلُ

مَعَ رَسُولِ اللَّهِ ﷺ.

Get out of our faces so we can strike the enemy. Wretched is what you have accustomed your opponents to! This is not how we used to fight alongside the Messenger of Allah ﷺ.

al-Yamama, 12 AH

A wretched bearer of the Qur'an

وقال المهاجرون لسالم مولى أبي حذيفة: أتخشى أن نؤتى من قبلك؟ فقال: بئس
حامل القرآن أنا إذا

*The Muhajirun said to Salim, the freedman of Abu Hudhayfa:
do you fear we shall be broken from your side? He said: a
wretched bearer of the Qur'an I should be, then.*

Adorn the Qur'an with deeds

وقال أبو حذيفة: يا أهل القرآن زينوا القرآن بالفعال، وحمل فيهم حتى أبعدهم

وأصيب

Abu Hudhayfa said: people of the Qur'an — adorn the Qur'an with deeds. And he charged into them until he drove them back, and he was struck down.

al-Yamama, then Medina

The armour in the cooking pot

IMAGE GOES HERE

Restrained editorial still life in muted ochre, bone and deep teal. At the far edge of an emptied desert camp at dusk: a large blackened cooking pot turned upside down on bare stony ground, with a worn wooden camel pack-

expected: series/visuals/l02_cooking_pot.png

An upturned pot at the far end of the camp, a pack-saddle on top.

A will carried out after his death

فأنفذ أبو بكر وصيَّته بعد موته، فلا نعلم أحدًا جازت وصيَّته بعد موته إلا

ثابت بن قيس بن شماس.

And Abu Bakr executed his will after his death. And we know of no one else whose will was carried through after his death except Thabit b. Qays b. Shammās.

I find the scent of Paradise

يا أبا عمرو أين؟ واهّا لريح الجنة، أجده دون أحدٍ.

Abu Amr, where to? Ah, the scent of Paradise — I find it this side of Uhud.

Known by his fingertips

﴿مِنَ الْمُؤْمِنِينَ رِجَالٌ صَدَقُوا مَا عَاهَدُوا اللَّهَ عَلَيْهِ﴾ [الأحزاب :

٢٣]

Among the believers are men true to what they pledged to Allah.

Medina or Basra, undated

Do you see me dying in my bed?

أَتَرَانِي أَمُوتُ عَلَى فِرَاشِي؟ وَاللَّهِ لَقَدْ قَتَلْتُ بِضْعاً وَتِسْعِينَ.

Do you see me dying in my bed? By Allah, I have killed ninety-odd.

Siyar A'lam al-Nubala', vol. 1, p. 198

The gate was shut from the inside

IMAGE GOES HERE

Restrained editorial illustration in muted ochre and bone with deep teal shadow. A high solid mud-brick wall running right across the frame, with one heavy timber gate shut fast in it; the crowns of date palms visible ab

expected: series/visuals/l02_shut_gate.png

Eighty-odd wounds. Khalid ٱ was a month treating them. He survived.

Throw me over onto them

يَا مَعْشَرَ الْمُسْلِمِينَ، أَتُقُونِي عَلَيْهِمْ فِي الْحَدِيقَةِ. فَقَالُوا: لَا نَفْعَلُ، فَقَالَ: وَاللَّهِ
لَتَطْرَحُنِي عَلَيْهِمْ بِهَا ... ! وَقَاتَلَ عَلَى الْبَابِ وَفَتَحَهُ لِلْمُسْلِمِينَ.

Company of Muslims — throw me over onto them into the garden. They said: we will not. He said: By Allah, you will throw me onto them in it!

al-Kamil fi al-Tarikh, vol. 2, p. 218

One house, Uhud and al-Yamama

The servant

Anas b. Malikؓ , the
Prophet's ﷺ servant
for ten years

The brother

al-Bara' b. Malikؓ , the
man on the shield

The uncle

Anas b. al-Nadrؓ ,
eighty-odd wounds at
Uhud

One house. The same count of wounds, and one got up.

al-Yamama, 12 AH

The arrow he pulled out

أصابه سهم يوم اليمامة فنزعه، وتحزم وأخذ السيف وقاتل حتى قتل، فوجد به
جراحات كثيرة.

An arrow struck him on the day of al-Yamama and he pulled it out, bound himself up, took his sword and fought until he was killed — and many wounds were found on him.

Lay me down between them

فلما صرع قال لأصحابه: ما فعل أبو حذيفة؟ قالوا: قُتل، قال: فما فعل فلان؟

قالوا: قُتل، قال: فأضجعوني بينهما

When he was struck down he said: what has become of Abu Hudhayfa? They said: he has been killed. He said: then lay me down between the two of them.

after al-Yamama, 12 AH

How they were found

وَقِيلَ : إِنَّ سَالِمًا وَجَدَ هُوَ وَمَوْلَاهُ أَبُو حُذَيْفَةَ، رَأْسُ أَحَدِهِمَا عِنْدَ رِجْلَي الْآخَرِ
صَرِيْعَيْنِ - رَضِيَ اللَّهُ عَنْهُمَا -

And it is said: Salim was found, he and his patron Abu Hudhayfa, the head of one of them at the feet of the other, both struck down.

I do not hear

فيقول: أتشهدُ أني رسولُ الله؟ فيقول: لا أسمع، فجعل يقطّعه عضوًا عضوًا
حتى مات في يديه، لا يزيدُه على ذلك.

Then he would say: do you testify that I am the Messenger of Allah? And he would say: I do not hear. So he began to cut him apart limb by limb until he died in his hands.

What Wahshi ُ said afterwards

وَعَنْ وَحْشِيِّ، قَالَ: لَمْ أَرَ قَطُّ أَصْبَرَ عَلَى الْمَوْتِ مِنْ أَصْحَابِ مُسَيْلِمَةَ، ثُمَّ ذَكَرَ
أَنَّهُ شَارَكَ فِي قَتْلِ مُسَيْلِمَةَ.

From Wahshi: I never saw men more steadfast in the face of death than Musaylima's companions — then he mentioned that he had a share in killing Musaylima.

The same spear, at al-Yamama

فَرُبُّكَ أَعْلَمُ أَيُّنَا قَتَلَهُ، فَإِنْ كُنْتُ قَتَلْتُهُ، فَقَدْ قَتَلْتُ خَيْرَ النَّاسِ بَعْدَ رَسُولِ اللَّهِ

ﷺ، وَقَتَلْتُ شَرَّ النَّاسِ

Your Lord knows best which of us killed him. If I killed him, then I have killed the best of men after the Messenger of Allah ﷺ, and I have killed the worst of men.

The witness against the enemy

لَمْ أَرَ قَطُّ أَصْبَرَ عَلَى الْمَوْتِ مِنْ أَصْحَابِ مُسَيْلِمَةَ

I have never seen anyone more steadfast in the face of death than Musaylima's men.

He outstripped me to both

وقد قال عمر لما بلغه مقتلُ زيد بن الخطاب : سبقني إلى الحُسَينِ، أسلمَ قبلي،
واستشهد قبلي.

*When the killing of Zayd b. al-Khattab reached Umar he said:
he outstripped me to the two good things — he accepted Islam
before me, and he was martyred before me.*

the years after 12 AH

The east wind

IMAGE GOES HERE

Restrained editorial landscape in muted ochre, bone and deep teal. A wide empty stony plain seen low and level at the end of the day, with fine dust and a few dry grass heads bent all one way by a steady wind coming from

expected: series/visuals/l02_east_wind.png

al-Saba is the east wind. It comes from the direction of al-Yamama.

the years after 12 AH

I find in it the scent of Zayd

وَكَانَ يَقُولُ: مَا هَبَّتِ الصَّبَا إِلَّا وَأَنَا أَجِدُ رِيحَ زَيْدٍ.

He used to say: the east wind never blows but I find in it the scent of Zayd.

What it cost, and what it produced

Act Four · 12 AH

12 AH, after the battle

The number nobody can give

وذلك بعد ما استَحَرَّ القُتْلُ في القُرَّاء يوم اليمامة كما ثبت به الحديث في
صحيح البخاري.

*...and that was after the killing had run hot among the reciters
on the day of al-Yamama, as the hadith in Sahih al-Bukhari
establishes.*

And Allah knows best

وقتل من المسلمين ستمئة، وقيل: خمسمئة، فالله أعلم، وفيهم من سادات

الصحابة، وأعيان الناس من يُذكر بعد

Six hundred of the Muslims were killed — and it is said five hundred — and Allah knows best. Among them were leaders of the Companions and men of standing.

Take the Qur'an from four

وهو أحد الأربعة الذين قال فيهم رسول الله ﷺ: "استقرئوا القرآن من أربعة"

فذكر منهم سالمًا مولى أبي حذيفة

And he is one of the four of whom the Messenger of Allah ﷺ said: take the Qur'an from four — and he mentioned Salim, the freedman of Abu Hudhayfa, among them.

A thing the Messenger ﷺ did not do

فَقُلْتُ : كَيْفَ تَفْعَلُونَ شَيْئاً لَمْ يَفْعَلْهُ رَسُولُ اللَّهِ - صَلَّى اللَّهُ عَلَيْهِ وَسَلَّمَ . - قَالَ :
هُوَ - وَاللَّهِ - خَيْرٌ . فَلَمْ يَزَلْ أَبُو بَكْرٍ يُرَاجِعُنِي حَتَّى شَرَحَ اللَّهُ صَدْرِي لِلَّذِي شَرَحَ
لَهُ صَدْرَ أَبِي بَكْرٍ وَعُمَرَ

I said: how will you do a thing the Messenger of Allah ﷺ did not do? He said: by Allah, it is good. And he did not stop coming back to me until Allah opened my breast.

Siyar A'lam al-Nubala', vol. 2, p. 431

12 AH

There was no volume to copy from

IMAGE GOES HERE

Restrained editorial still life in muted ochre, bone and deep teal, laid out on a plain scrubbed wooden surface and seen from directly above. Four kinds of thing set well apart from one another: strips of aged parchment;

expected: series/visuals/l02_four_materials.png

Parchment, shoulder-blades, palm-stalks — and the breasts of men.

He tracked it down, piece by piece

فَكُنْتُ أَتَّبَعُ الْقُرْآنَ، أَجْمَعُهُ مِنَ الرِّقَاعِ، وَالْأَكْتَافِ، وَالْعُسْبِ، وَصُدُورِ الرِّجَالِ.

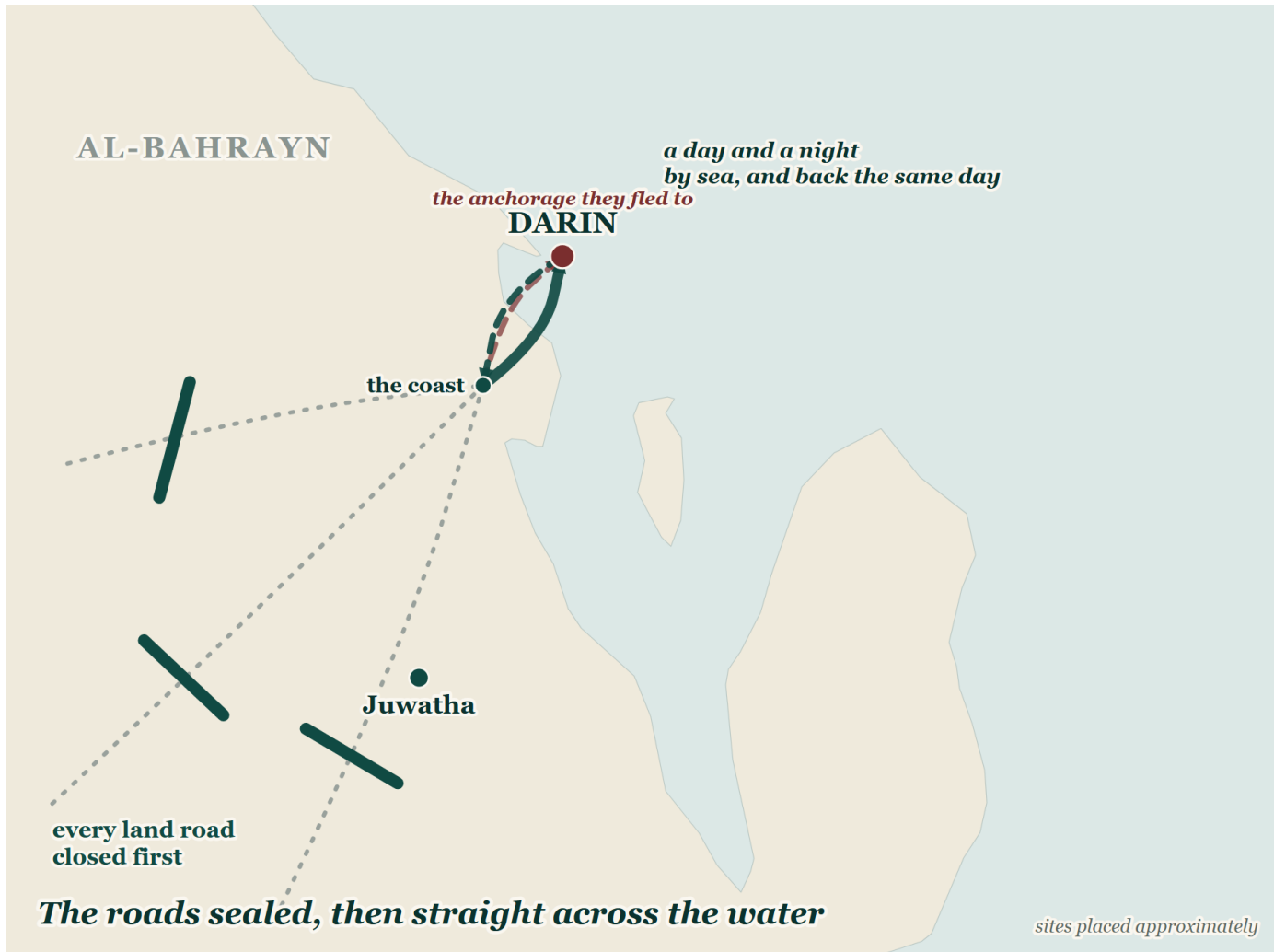
So I began to track down the Qur'an, gathering it from the parchments, the shoulder-blades, the palm-stalks, and the breasts of men.

Arabia whole again

Act Five · 12 AH

11-12 AH

Darin — into the water



al-Bahrayn

the beaten take ship

The land roads

closed behind them first

Darin

a day and a night by sea

Across the water

out and back in one day

What was lost

one man's horse-fodder

Go straight across the sea

قَدْ أَرَأَكُمُ اللَّهُ مِنْ آيَاتِهِ فِي الْبَرِّ لَتَعْتَبِرُوا بِهَا فِي الْبَحْرِ، فَانْهَضُوا إِلَى عَدُوِّكُمْ
وَاسْتَغَرِضُوا الْبَحْرَ.

Allah has shown you of His signs on land so that you may take heed of them at sea. Rise against your enemy, and go straight across the sea.

Not until you have proved yourself

وَكَتَبَ إِلَيْهِ الصِّدِّيقُ يَلُومُهُ عَلَى تَسْرُعِهِ، قَالَ: لَا أَرِيَنَّكَ وَلَا أَسْمَعَنَّ بِكَ إِلَّا بَعْدَ

بَلَاءٍ

al-Siddiq wrote blaming him for his haste, and said: let me not see you, and let me not hear of you, except after you have proved yourself.

his later life

My Lord's speech, my Lord's speech

وَكَانَ يُقَبِّلُ الْمُصْحَفَ وَيَبْكِي وَيَقُولُ : كَلَامُ رَبِّي ، كَلَامُ رَبِّي ... وَيُقَالُ : إِنَّهُ لَا
يُعْرَفُ لَهُ ذَنْبٌ بَعْدَ مَا أَسْلَمَ

He used to kiss the mushaf and weep and say: my Lord's speech, my Lord's speech ... and it is said that no sin is known of him after he accepted Islam.

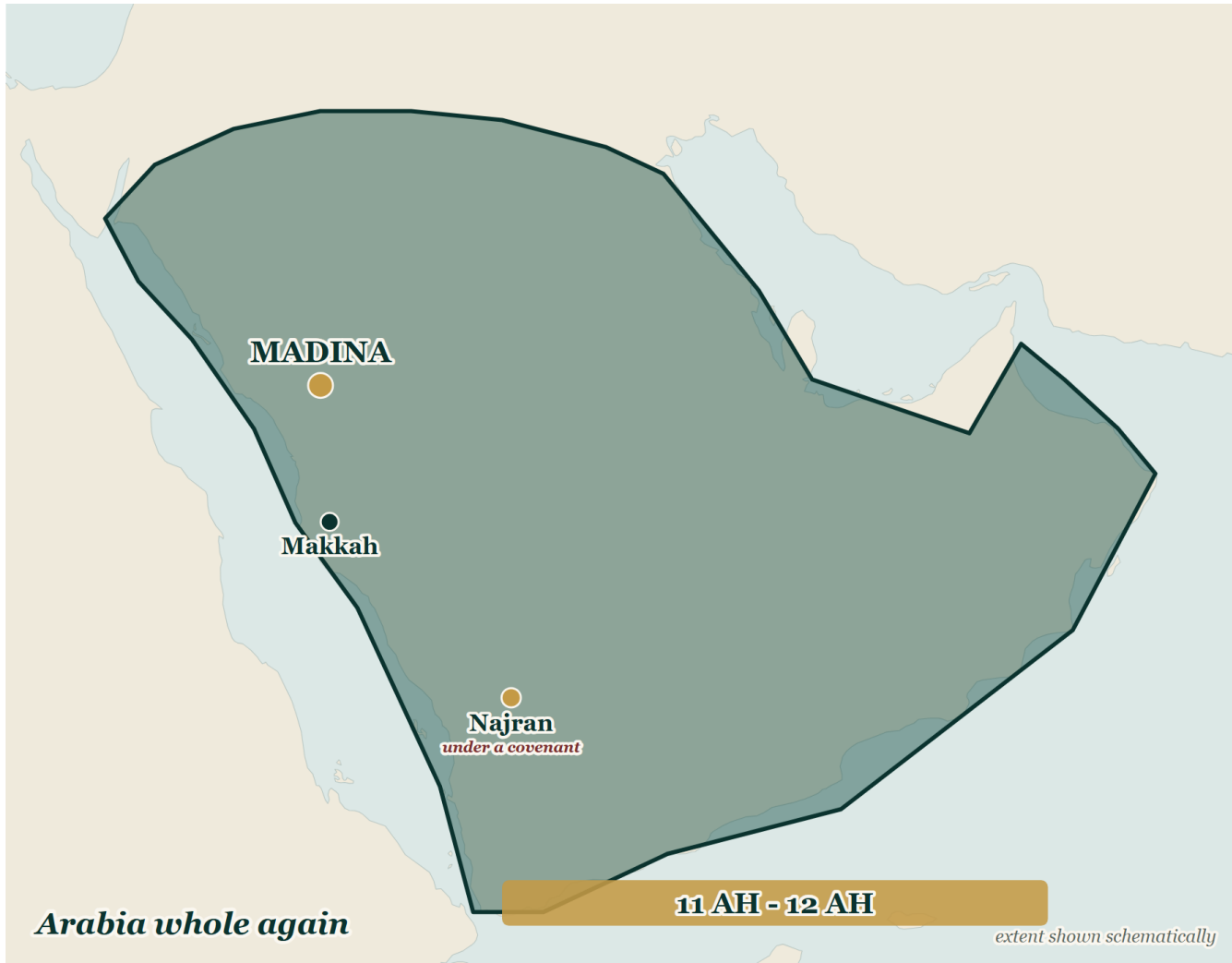
اغْرُبْ عَنِّي فَإِنَّكَ قَاتِلُ الرَّجُلَيْنِ الصَّالِحَيْنِ، عُكَّاشَةُ بْنُ مُحْصَنٍ، وَثَابِتُ بْنُ أَقْرَمَ،
فَقَالَ: يَا أَمِيرَ الْمُؤْمِنِينَ هُمَا رَجُلَانِ أَكْرَمَهُمَا اللَّهُ عَلَى يَدَيَّ وَلَمْ يُهَيِّ بِأَيْدِيهِمَا .
فَأَعْجَبَ عُمَرَ كَلَامُهُ وَرَضِيَ عَنْهُ

Get away from me — you are the killer of the two righteous men. Allah honoured them at my hands.

al-Bidaya wa-l-Nihaya, vol. 7, p. 242

11 AH → 12 AH

Arabia whole again



Every region
no part untouched

The armies
a support to believers

The fifth
of the spoils, spent

Najran
renewed its covenant

Just over a year
late 11 AH to early 12

11 AH → 12 AH

What Ibn Kathir says it was

ولم يزل الأمر كذلك حتى لم يبق بجزيرة العرب إلا أهل طاعة لله ولرسوله، وأهل
ذمة من الصديق، كأهل نجران وما جرى مجراهم والله الحمد.

*And matters continued so until there remained in the peninsula
none but people obedient to Allah and His Messenger, and
people under al-Siddiq's protection.*

al-Bidaya wa-l-Nihaya, vol. 7, p. 43

والسبب في ذلك ... أنَّ الصبغة الدينية تذهب بالتنافس والتحاسد الذي في
أهل العصبية وتفرد الوجهة إلى الحق فإذا حصل لهم الاستبصار في أمرهم لم
يقف لهم شيء لأنَّ الوجهة واحدة والمطلوب متساو عندهم وهم مستमितون

*The religious colouring takes away the rivalry and envy that
are in people of asabiyya, and makes their direction one.*

Ibn Khaldun · Tarikh Ibn Khaldun, vol. 1, p. 198 — as he reads it

Ninety seconds

Mark three places on the map. Write three years into the boxes.

Outward

Act Six · 12–13 AH

Two restrictions that are easy to miss

وأمره أن لا يُكرِه أحدًا على المسير معه، ولا يستعينُ بمن ارتدَّ عن الإسلام

*And he ordered him not to compel any man to march with him,
and not to use any man who had apostatised.*

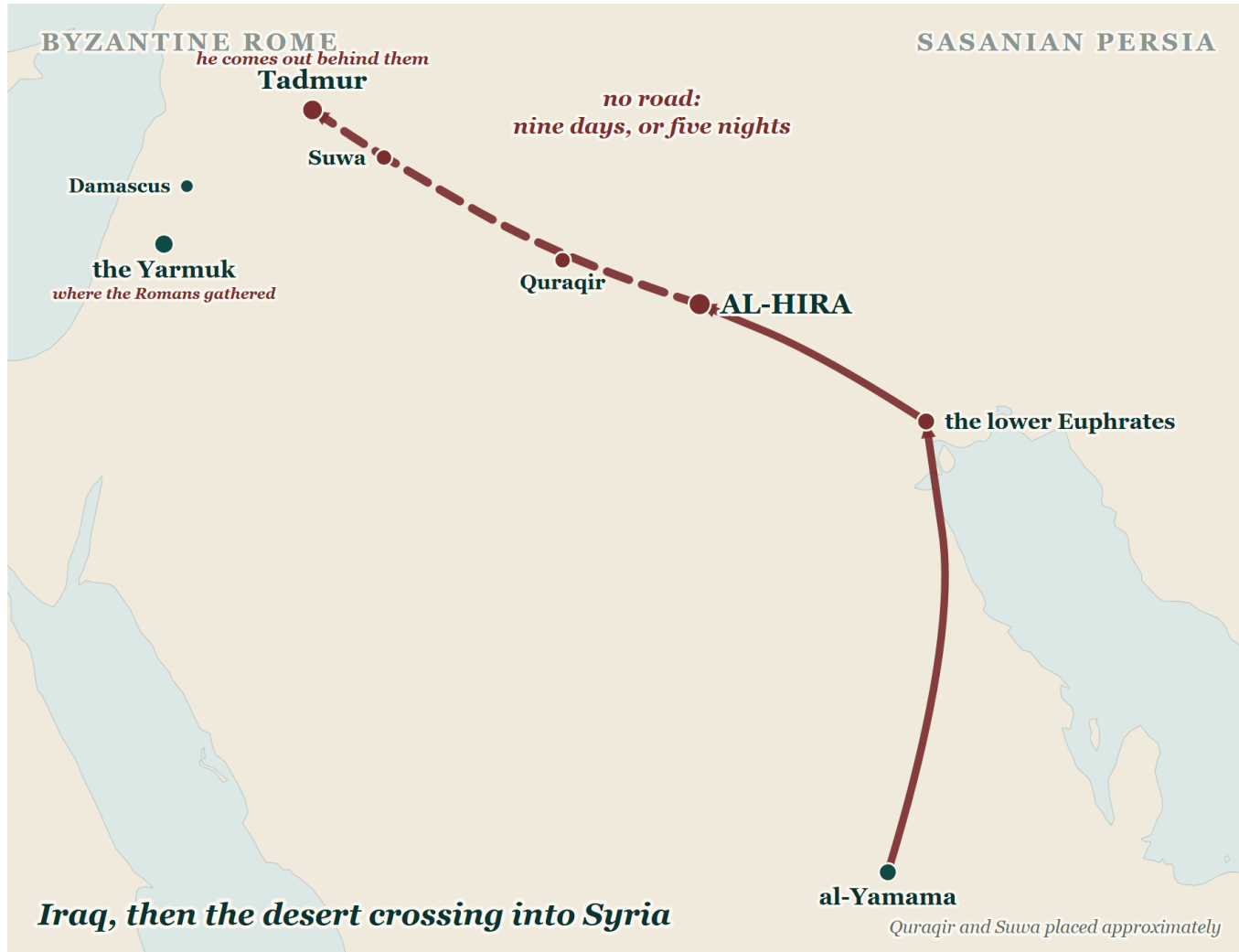
He walked beside the stirrup

عَقَدَ لَهُ أَبُو بَكْرٍ، وَمَشَى مَعَهُ تَحْتَ رِكَابِهِ يُسَايِرُهُ، وَيُودِّعُهُ، وَيُوصِيهِ، وَمَا ذَاكَ
إِلَّا لِشَرَفِهِ، وَكَمَالِ دِينِهِ

Abu Bakr tied his standard for him and walked beside him under his stirrup, seeing him off and instructing him — and that was only for his standing.

13 AH

Five days of waterless country



al-Hira

Iraq from its lower end

Quraqir

strikes north-west

The Samawa

nine days, five nights

Suwa and Tadmur

out behind the Romans

The guide

Rafi' b. Umayra al-Ta'i

Only once in my life

وَاللّٰهُ مَا وَرَدْتُ هَٰذَا الْمَآءَ قَطُّ إِلَّا مَرَّةً وَاحِدَةً مَّعَ أَبِي وَأَنَا غُلَامٌ

By God, I have come to this water only once in my life — with my father, when I was a boy.

إن هذا يوم من أيام الله، لا ينبغي فيه الفخر ولا البغي ... فتعالوا فلنتعاور
الإمارة فليكن عليها بعضنا اليوم والآخر غدًا والآخر بعد غد، حتى يتأمر
كلكم، ودعوني اليوم أليكم

Let us take the command in turn — one of us today, another tomorrow — and let me have today.

the Yarmuk, 13 AH

Armies are made many by victory

ويلك، أتخوّفني بالروم؟ وإنما تكثر الجنود بالنصر، وتقل بالخذلان لا بعدد

الرجال

Woe to you — are you frightening me with the Romans? Armies are made many by victory and few by abandonment, not by the number of men.

He dies

Act Seven · 13 AH

the last days

There is harshness in him

فَقَالَ: إِنَّهُ أَفْضَلُ مِنْ رَأْيِكَ إِلَّا أَنَّهُ فِيهِ غِلْظَةٌ. فَقَالَ أَبُو بَكْرٍ: ذَلِكَ لِأَنَّهُ يَرَانِي رَقِيقًا، وَلَوْ أَفْضَى الْأَمْرُ إِلَيْهِ لَتَرَكَ كَثِيرًا مِمَّا هُوَ عَلَيْهِ

He is better than your opinion of him — except that there is harshness in him. Abu Bakr said: that is because he sees me being gentle.

al-Kamil fi al-Tarikh, vol. 2, p. 266

the last days

I have not appointed a relative over you

أَتَرْضُونَ بِمَنْ اسْتَخْلَفْتُ عَلَيْكُمْ؟ فَإِنِّي مَا اسْتَخْلَفْتُ عَلَيْكُمْ ذَا قَرَابَةٍ، وَإِنِّي قَدْ
اسْتَخْلَفْتُ عَلَيْكُمْ عُمَرَ فَاسْمَعُوا لَهُ وَأَطِيعُوا، فَإِنِّي وَاللَّهِ مَا أَلَوْتُ مِنْ جُهِدِ الرَّأْيِ.

*Are you content with the one I have appointed over you? For I
have not appointed over you a relative of mine. I have
appointed Umar over you.*

al-Kamil fi al-Tarikh, vol. 2, p. 267

the last day

What in the house was not his

A servant

an Abyssinian, in the
house

A camel

used for carrying
water

A blanket

worn down to the nap

Send them to Umar when I die. And she did.

the last day

He closed the account himself

وليس عندنا من فيء المسلمين شيء إلا هذا العبد الحبشي وهذا البعير الناضح
وجرد هذه القطيفة، فإذا مت فابعثي بهن إلى عمر، ففعلت.

We have nothing of the Muslims' fay' except this Abyssinian servant, this water-carrying camel, and the worn nap of this blanket.

Siyar A'lam al-Nubala' (al-Khulafa' al-Rashidun), p. 19

the last days

Sell my land and pay them back

فَلَمَّا حَضَرَتْهُ الْوَفَاةُ أَوْصَى أَنْ تُبَاعَ أَرْضٌ لَهُ وَيُصْرَفَ ثَمَنُهَا عِوَضَ مَا أَخَذَهُ مِنْ
مَالِ الْمُسْلِمِينَ.

When death came to him he directed that land of his be sold and its price paid over in compensation for what he had taken of the Muslims' property.

The living need the new more

وَقَالَ: الْحَيُّ أَحْوَجُ إِلَى الْجَدِيدِ مِنَ الْمَيِّتِ، إِنَّمَا هُوَ لِلْمُهْلَةِ
وَالصَّادِدِ.

*He said: the living have more need of the new than the dead —
this is only for the decay.*

13 AH

Three graves, one behind the other

The Prophet ﷺ

the first of the three

Abu Bakrؓ

his head at the
Prophet's ﷺ shoulders

Umarؓ

later, his head at Abu
Bakr's waist

Four men went down: his son, Umar, Uthman and Talha.

Buried before morning came

وقالت عائشة: مات ليلة الثلاثاء، ودفن قبل أن يصبح.

A'isha ؓ said: he died on the night of Tuesday, and was buried before morning came.

Had Salim   been alive

وروي عن عمر أنه قال لما احتُضِر: لو كانَ سالمٌ حيًّا لما جعلتها شُورى

And it is related of Umar that he said, when death was upon him: had Salim been alive I would not have made it a shura.

Bookend out

What year are we in now?



11 AH to 13 AH. Two years and three months.

13 AH

Where we stand now



Arabia

whole, and under one authority

Iraq

entered from its lower end

Syria

the armies are on the Yarmuk

The dashed outline

where the map stood when you walked in

Tonight

There is a kind of steadiness that is not stubbornness: it is refusing to treat an emergency as permission.

The whole war was set moving from one camp, in one sitting, by a man who had just been told to go home.

The tie was made in a year when they owned nothing, and it was still holding on the day they died.

Preservation is not one heroic act; it is somebody doing a careful, unglamorous job properly.

He kept an account of what was not his, and he closed it before he died.

Next week

He said the office would take much of that hardness away. Next week — did it?